Leader resource · all twelve posted studies · NASB95

Colossians: Charts from the Twelve Studies

Every chart from the twelve Colossians studies, in study order — one section per study, with leader notes on every slide.

The series at a glance (1 of 2)

Studies 1–6

Study	Passage	Title	In one line
01	1:1–8	**Faith, Love, and Hope in Colossae**	The gospel of grace first heard is true, worldwide and fruitful — and the Christ it proclaims is enough.
02	1:9–14	**Paul's Prayer for the Colossians**	Pray for knowledge that becomes a worthy walk — anchored in what the Father has already done.
03	1:15–23	**The Savior of the Gospel**	Christ is first in creation, first in the Church and first through the cross — and if He is all that, He is enough.
04	1:24–29	**Christ in You, the Hope of Glory**	God's secret is out: Christ lives in every believer — and He is leading each one toward maturity and glory.
05	2:1–7	**The Believer's Education**	Every treasure is already in Christ — so keep walking in Him the way you began: by grace, through faith.
06	2:8–15	**Beware of Philosophy**	All the fullness of God dwells in Christ — and in Him you are complete, forgiven, debt-free and on the winning side.

The series at a glance (2 of 2)

Studies 7–12

Study	Passage	Title	In one line
07	2:16–23	**Run the Race Set Before You**	Don’t trade the substance for the shadow: run your race holding fast to the Head, not to a list of rules.
08	3:1–11	**Looking Up, Putting Off**	Look up, then take off the old clothes: bring your practice up to your position, because Christ is all, and in all.
09	3:12–17	**Service Manual for the Lord’s Army**	The Lord’s army wears Christ’s character, held together by love — ruled by His peace, filled with His Word, acting in His name.
10	3:18–4:1	**The Relationships of the New Man**	At home and at work, every relationship is service to the Lord Christ — equal in worth, ordered in function.
11	4:2–6	**Perfecting the Prayer Life**	Pray on your knees, walk wisely before outsiders, and talk with grace — God opens the doors.
12	4:7–18	**Portrait of a Ministry Team**	No one can do it all — God builds a team of grace and calls each member to fulfill the ministry received from Him.

Study 1 of 12 · Colossians 1:1–8

Faith, Love, and Hope in Colossae

Writing from prison to a church he had never seen, Paul greets the Colossians with grace and peace and thanks God for the faith, love and hope the true gospel produced in them — the foundation for a letter that exalts Christ as all-sufficient.

How the gospel reached Colossae

Background I.A · The church Paul had never seen (1:4, 7–8; 2:1)

Paul at Ephesus	All Asia hears	Epaphras	The Lycus Valley	Paul in Rome
Three years in Ephesus; two of them teaching daily in the school of Tyrannus	“All who lived in Asia heard the word of the Lord, both Jews and Greeks”	A Colossian who apparently heard Paul and carried the message home	Churches born in Colossae, Laodicea and Hierapolis, about a hundred miles east	Under guard in rented quarters, he writes to a church he has never seen
Acts 19:9–10	Acts 19:10	Col 1:7; 4:12	Col 4:13	Acts 28:30

Paul did not have to go everywhere himself — God multiplied His Word through a faithful learner who became a teacher.

Five marks of the Colossian heresy

Background I.B · An early form of Gnosticism

1 Jewish · 2:11, 16

Old Testament laws, foods, festivals and Sabbaths

2 Philosophical · 2:3–4, 8

γνῶσις
A deeper knowledge for the initiated

3 Angel worship · 2:18

Angels as mediators between man and God

4 Exclusive · 1:28; 3:11

“Perfection” for a select spiritual elite

5 Christological · 1:15–19; 2:9

It diminished the deity of Christ

× The root: dualism

Spirit is good, matter is evil — so there can be no God-Man

Paul answers every one of these with a Person: Christ is all, and Christ is enough.

Two errors about Jesus — one answer

Background I.B.1–2 · Where dualism leads

The Cerinthians a man, but not God		**The Docetists** δοκέω dokeō · “to seem” — God, but not man
Named for their founder, Cerinthus		Jesus was only God
“The Christ,” a spirit, came upon Jesus at His baptism and left before the cross	vs	He only seemed to have a body
The man Jesus died only as a man		God, in His divine nature, cannot die
A mere man cannot die for the world		No real body means no real death for sin

“In Him all the fullness of Deity dwells in bodily form” (2:9) — fully God and fully man, one Person forever.

Grace in four dimensions, peace in three

Colossians 1:2 · Outline II.D — The salutation

Grace χάρις charis · G5485	**Peace** εἰρήνη eirēnē · G1515 · Heb. shalom
Saving grace — forgiveness and eternal life to all who believe (Eph 2:8–9)	Peace with God — settled at justification by faith (Rom 5:1)
Sanctifying grace — conforming us to the image of the Son	The God of peace — company for a godly walk (Phil 4:9)
Serving grace — acceptable service only by grace (Heb 12:28)	The peace of God — a guard over heart and mind in hard circumstances (Phil 4:6–7)
Sharing grace — the generous giving of the Macedonians (2 Cor 8:1–7)	

Peace with God is a fact, not a feeling. The peace of God stands guard between us and the problem.

Faith, love and hope — three directions

Colossians 1:4–5a · Outline III.B — The reasons for thanksgiving

Faith looks up	Love looks out	Hope looks ahead
πίστις Rests on the past — the finished work of Christ. Its object is a Person.	**ἀγάπη** Works in the present — toward “all the saints,” not an inner circle	**ἐλπίς · ἀπόκειμαι** Confident expectation, “laid up” — stored and reserved in heaven
v.4a · “in Christ Jesus”	v.4b	v.5a

They loved “because of the hope laid up for you in heaven.” Assurance is not a barrier to love — it fuels it.

The gospel they first heard

Colossians 1:5b–6 · Outline III.C — The source of it all

A **Its universality · v.6a**

“Has come to you, just as in all the world also” — not a private message for an elite

B **Its productivity · v.6b**

καρποφορέω
“Constantly bearing fruit and increasing” — of itself, by its own life

C **Its individuality · v.6c**

“Even as it has been doing in you also” — the worldwide message became personal

D **Its identity · v.6d**

“The grace of God in truth” — add anything to grace and it is no longer the gospel

The Colossians didn’t need a newer, deeper, more exclusive message. The gospel they first heard was enough.

Epaphras: the man God used

Colossians 1:7–8 · Outline III.D — The messenger

1	**A student of Paul** “Just as you learned it from Epaphras” — trained in Ephesus, he carried the message home	**v.7a** learner, then teacher
2	**A beloved fellow bond-servant** Paul does not rank himself above him — slaves of the same Master	**σύνδουλος** co-slave
3	**A faithful servant of Christ** NASB95: “on our behalf” — he went in Paul’s place. NKJV: “on your behalf.” Either way, faithful.	**διάκονος** servant
4	**A messenger from them** “He also informed us of your love in the Spirit” — love produced by the Holy Spirit	**v.8** Spirit-given love

Before Paul answers a single error, he thanks God for grace at work — and for the man who brought it.

Discuss and apply

Colossians 1:1–8 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. Why would the Colossian heresy's view of matter lead to a wrong view of Jesus — and why does that matter for salvation?

2. According to verse 5, why did the Colossians love all the saints? What does that suggest about assurance and love?

Apply

Let Your Hope Fuel Your Love
Choose one person in your church you seldom speak with and do one concrete act of kindness for them.

Thank God for Your Epaphras
Send a short note of thanks this week to the person who brought you the gospel.

In one line: The gospel of grace first heard is true, worldwide and fruitful — and the Christ it proclaims is enough.

Study 2 of 12 · Colossians 1:9–14

Paul’s Prayer for the Colossians

Paul prays that believers will be filled with the knowledge of God’s will so they may walk worthy of the Lord — a walk seen in fruit, growth, joyful endurance and thanks to the Father who qualified, rescued, transferred and redeemed them.

Paul’s prayer as a building

Colossians 1:9–14 · The commentary’s outline

I. The foundation	II. The superstructure	III. The outer part
ἐπίγνωσις Filled with the knowledge of His will, in all spiritual wisdom and understanding	**περιπατέω** A walk worthy of the Lord, pleasing Him in all respects	What people see: fruit, growth, power to endure, and thanksgiving
v.9	v.10a	vv.10b–14

Knowledge is never an end in itself. The goal of knowing God’s will is doing it.

Three words for one need

Colossians 1:9 · Outline I.B — The foundation: knowledge

1 Knowledge

ἐπίγνωσις epignōsis · G1922
Full, accurate, personal knowledge — the false teachers boasted of gnōsis; Paul prays for epi-gnōsis

2 Wisdom

σοφία sophia · G4678
The skill to use that knowledge in real life, including the discernment to spot error

3 Understanding

σύνεσις synesis · G4907
To “bring things together” — set each error beside the Scripture that refutes it

✓ “Filled” · “spiritual”

πληρόω Aor. Pass. Subj.
Not something added from outside — filled with what God has revealed, by the Spirit

The best defense against counterfeit knowledge is full, accurate knowledge of God’s will.

Already accepted — so we aim to please

Colossians 1:10a · Outline II — The superstructure: a worthy walk

What the walk is not	vs	What the walk is ἀρεσκεία areskeia · “to please”
Not the price of eternal life		The fitting response to a gift already received
Not currying favor to get accepted (the old sense of areskeia)		Delighting the Lord “in all respects” — every area of life
Not striving for a status we lack		A life that matches the worth of the Lord we represent

Already saints, qualified, rescued and redeemed (1:2, 12–14) — the worthy walk flows from acceptance, never toward it.

What people see: four marks of a worthy walk

Colossians 1:10b–12 · Outline III — The outer part

v.10b	Bearing fruit in every good work — the fruitful gospel (v.6) produces fruitful people	**καρποφορέω** same verb as v.6
v.10c	Increasing in the knowledge of God — knowledge leads to obedience, obedience to deeper knowledge	**ἐπίγνωσις** growth by the Word
v.11	Strengthened with all power, according to His glorious might — not for show, but for go	**δυναμόω** Pres. Pass. — a continuous supply
v.11	Steadfastness — “remaining under” pressures, persecutions and temptations	**ὑπομονή** toward circumstances
v.11	Patience — “long-tempered” restraint that refuses to retaliate	**μακροθυμία** toward people
v.12	Joyously giving thanks to the Father	**εὐχαριστέω** endurance with joy

Four things the Father has already done

Colossians 1:12–14 · Outline III.D — Giving thanks to the Father

1	**He qualified us — v.12** Made us fit to share in the inheritance of the saints in Light. We did not qualify ourselves.	**ἱκανόω** Aor. — done
2	**He rescued us — v.13a** Drew us out of “the domain of darkness,” a realm ruled by a tyrant	**ῥύομαι** to rescue, draw to oneself
3	**He transferred us — v.13b** Relocated us to the kingdom of His beloved Son: a new address and a new King	**μεθίστημι** to resettle a people
4	**He redeemed us — v.14** Release by payment of a price — “the forgiveness of sins,” sins sent away	**ἀπολύτρωσις** ransom-release

The false teachers wanted believers to strive for a status they already had. Paul wants them to enjoy it and give thanks.

Discuss and apply

Colossians 1:9–14 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. How does Paul become part of the answer to his own prayer, and what does that suggest for us?

2. Distinguish “steadfastness” from “patience” in verse 11. Where do you need each right now?

Apply

Upgrade Your Prayer List
Choose three people and pray verses 9–12 for them by name every day this week.

Give Thanks for What Is Already Done
Read verses 12–14 aloud each day and thank God for each of the four gifts by name.

In one line: Pray for knowledge that becomes a worthy walk — anchored in what the Father has already done.

Study 3 of 12 · Colossians 1:15–23

The Savior of the Gospel

Jesus Christ is supreme over creation as its Creator and Sustainer, supreme over the Church as its Head and the firstborn from the dead, and supreme in reconciliation — believers, already reconciled, will be presented holy and blameless as they continue in the faith.

Christ first in everything

Colossians 1:15–23 · The commentary's outline

I. Christ and creation	II. Christ and the Church	III. Christ and the cross
Image of God · Firstborn over creation · Creator · Sustainer	Head of the body · Firstborn from the dead · Fullness of God · Reconciler	Requirement · Remedy · Reason · Condition for being presented
vv.15–17	vv.18–20	vv.21–23

"So that He Himself will come to have first place in everything" (v.18) — πρωτεύω, found only here in the NT.

Christ and creation, verse by verse

Colossians 1:15–17 · Outline I.A–D

v.15a	The picture of God — “the image of the invisible God”: He makes the unseen God seen (John 14:9)	**εἰκών** representation and manifestation
v.15b	Priority over creation — “firstborn”: the rank and rights of the heir, not the first created	**πρωτότοκος** preeminence (Ps 89:27)
v.16	Creator of the universe — heavens and earth, visible and invisible, thrones, dominions, rulers, authorities	**κτίζω** Aor. the act · Perf. the abiding result
v.17	Sustainer of the universe — “before all things, and in Him all things hold together”	**συνίστημι** Perf. — to stand together, cohere

The very angels the Colossians were tempted to worship (2:18) were created by Christ. They are creatures.

“Firstborn” and “only begotten”

Colossians 1:15b · Outline I.B — He has priority over creation

Firstborn
πρωτότοκος prōtotokos · G4416

- Stresses rank — the rights of the heir
- David made “firstborn,” though the youngest son (Ps 89:27)
- Israel called God’s firstborn (Exod 4:22)
- Christ is preeminent over all creation

vs

Only begotten
μονογενής monogenēs · John 3:16

- Stresses uniqueness
- Isaac, Abraham’s “only begotten son” (Heb 11:17) — though Abraham had other sons (Gen 25:1–2)
- Unique as the son of promise
- Jesus is the unique Son of God

If He created all things (v.16), He cannot Himself be a created thing.

Christ and the Church

Colossians 1:18–20 · Outline II.A–D

A Head of the body · v.18a

κεφαλή
Source of life and authority for the Church, the universal body all believers enter by Spirit baptism (1 Cor 12:13)

B Firstborn from the dead · v.18b

The first to rise to resurrection life, never to die again (Heb 2:14–15; 1 Cor 15:22–23)

C The fullness of God · v.19

πλήρωμα · κατοικέω
Not spread out among angels — permanently “at home” in Christ (2:9)

D Reconciler through the cross · v.20

ἀποκαταλλάσσω
Peace made “through the blood of His cross” — man reconciled to God, not God to man

“Reconcile all things” is not universal salvation: only those who believe are reconciled and have eternal life (John 3:16, 36).

Three sides of the atonement

Colossians 1:21–22a · Outline III.A–B — The requirement and remedy of the cross

Redemption sin-ward	**Reconciliation** man-ward	**Propitiation** God-ward
The price paid to free us Matthew 20:28	The barrier removed; we are brought back to God 2 Corinthians 5:18–20 “He has now reconciled you” (v.22)	God’s justice satisfied 1 John 2:2

“In His fleshly body through death” (v.22) — not a phantom body, not a mere man. The eternal Son died in real flesh.

Reconciled now — presented then

Colossians 1:22–23 · Outline III.C–D — The reason and the condition

Settled — not conditional
"He has now reconciled you" · v.22a

Past, complete and permanent

A gift received by faith (John 3:16)

Not dependent on a persevering life

vs

Conditional — the presentation
παρίστημι · ἀνέγκλητος · v.22b

To be presented holy, blameless, beyond reproach

"If indeed you continue in the faith" (v.23) — ei ge, first class condition

Linked with the Judgment Seat of Christ — reward, not eternal life

The "if" of verse 23 modifies "present," not "reconciled." The gift is secure; the presentation is the prize.

Discuss and apply

Colossians 1:15–23 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. How does verse 16 answer those who say “firstborn” means Christ was the first created being?

2. According to this study, what is conditional in verses 22–23, and what is not?

Apply

Give Christ First Place
Identify one area where Christ does not have first place and make one concrete change this week.

Reconciled Now, Presented Then
Name one influence that weakens your steadiness in the faith and take one step to limit it.

In one line: Christ is first in creation, first in the Church and first through the cross — and if He is all that, He is enough.

Study 4 of 12 · Colossians 1:24–29

Christ in You, the Hope of Glory

Paul rejoices to suffer for the Church and serves as its steward to make known God's long-hidden mystery — "Christ in you, the hope of glory" — laboring in Christ's power to present every believer mature in Christ.

Four movements of the mystery

Colossians 1:24–29 · The commentary's outline

I. The suffering	II. The stewardship	III. The secret	IV. The success
θλῖψις Paul rejoices to bear afflictions for Christ's body, the Church	**οἰκονομία** As God's steward he makes known what was hidden for ages	**μυστήριον** "Christ in you, the hope of glory" — even among Gentiles	**τέλειος** Presenting every believer complete in Christ
v.24	vv.25–26	v.27	vv.28–29

The false teachers offered mysteries for the few. God has revealed His mystery to all His saints — the indwelling Christ.

“Filling up what is lacking”?

Colossians 1:24 · Outline I.B — It is connected to the afflictions of Christ

What is not lacking	vs	What Paul fills up θλῖψις · ἀνταναπληρόω
The atonement — “It is finished!” (John 19:30)		Distress from outward circumstances (BDAG) — the trials of life
One offering perfects forever (Heb 10:14)		His share of the afflictions Christ’s body bears in serving Him
Thlipsis is never used in the NT of Christ’s atoning sufferings		“Saul, why are you persecuting Me?” (Acts 9:4) — the Head feels the body’s pain

Every believer strengthened by this letter is a beneficiary of Paul’s chains.

What the mystery is — and is not

Colossians 1:26–27 · Outline II.B and III — Hidden, now manifested

× Not simply Gentile salvation

Promised as early as Genesis 12:3 — all the families of the earth blessed through Abraham's seed

1 Jew and Gentile in one body

On the same level, in one body (Eph 3:3–6)

2 The indwelling Christ

"Christ in you"
The Messiah living in His people (Col 1:26–27)

3 The Church as the bride

Christ and the Church (Eph 5:32)

4 The rapture of the Church

"We will not all sleep" (1 Cor 15:51–52)

? A biblical mystery

μυστήριον
Not a puzzle for the clever — truth unknowable until God revealed it

“Christ in you, the hope of glory”

Colossians 1:27 · Outline III.A–C — The secret of the mystery

1	**God willed to reveal it** Revelation is progressive; through Paul and the apostles God gave the revelation for the Church age	**πλοῦτος** riches of the glory
2	**The Gentiles received it** Paul, apostle to the Gentiles (Rom 11:13); Peter first opened the door at Cornelius’s house (Acts 10–11)	**“among the Gentiles”**
3	**Christ in you defines it** The Messiah does not merely stand beside His people — He lives in them, as no Old Testament saint experienced	**the heart** of the mystery
4	**The hope of glory** Not the hope of heaven — settled at faith (1:13–14) — but of sharing Christ’s glory when He is revealed (3:4)	**δόξα** Heb. kavod

The goal, the means and the method

Colossians 1:28–29 · Outline IV — The success of the mystery

Means	“We proclaim Him” — the message is a Person, not a system or a set of rules	**—** v.28a
Means	Admonishing every man — warning wisely; you lead sheep, you cannot drive them	**νουθετέω** to put sense into the mind
Means	Teaching every man with all wisdom — told accurately, explained convincingly, applied lovingly	**—** v.28b
Goal	Present every man complete in Christ — at the Judgment Seat of Christ	**τέλειος** mature, full-grown — not sinless
Method	Laboring and striving — toil to weariness, an athlete’s strain	**κοπιάω · ἀγωνίζομαι** v.29a
Method	“According to His power, which mightily works within me”	**ἐνέργεια** God supplies the energy — and gets the credit

Discuss and apply

Colossians 1:24–29 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. How can Paul speak of “filling up what is lacking in Christ’s afflictions” without denying the finished work of the cross?

2. According to this study, what does “the hope of glory” refer to, and why does that matter?

Apply

Live Aware of the Indwelling Christ
Set a reminder three times a day this week — “Christ in you” — and pause to thank Him for His presence.

Invest in Someone’s Maturity
Invite one believer to read Colossians with you over the coming weeks.

In one line: God’s secret is out: Christ lives in every believer — and He is leading each one toward maturity and glory.

Study 5 of 12 · Colossians 2:1–7

The Believer’s Education

Paul labors for believers he has never seen so that, knit together in love, they will come to the full knowledge of God’s mystery — Christ Himself, the treasury of all wisdom — and keep walking in Him as they received Him.

Paul’s education for believers

Colossians 2:1–7 · The commentary’s outline

I. His wish	II. His warning	III. His assurance	IV. His admonition
ἀγών A struggle for unseen believers: hearts encouraged, knit in love, knowing Christ	**πιθανολογία** Let no one delude you with persuasive argument	**τάξις · στερέωμα** Absent in body, present in spirit — rejoicing in their order and firm faith	**περιπατεῖτε** As you received Christ Jesus the Lord, so walk in Him
vv.1–3	v.4	v.5	vv.6–7

The defense is already in place before the error is named: Christ is enough.

Three steps to strengthened hearts

Colossians 2:2–3 · Outline I.C — The reason for the wish

Prerequisite	Sub-purpose	Final purpose	In Him
συμβιβάζω Hearts knit together in love — joined like the body's joints	**πληροφορία** All the wealth of the full assurance of understanding — settled conviction	A true knowledge of God's mystery — Christ Himself	**θησαυρός · ἀπόκρυφος** "All the treasures of wisdom and knowledge" are hidden
v.2a · Aor. Pass. Ptc.	v.2b	v.2c	v.3

The real hidden treasures are not stored in a secret society. They are stored in Christ — open to every believer.

Not deluded — standing firm

Colossians 2:4–5 · Outline II–III — Paul's warning and assurance

The warning — v.4
παραλογίζομαι · πιθανολογία

"Delude" — to cheat by false reasoning

"Persuasive argument" — plausible, smooth talk (only here in the NT)

Today: "all religions are equally true paths to God"

Answer: John 14:6; Eph 2:8–9

vs

The assurance — v.5
τάξις · στερέωμα · military words

Good discipline — an army in unbroken ranks

Stability — a solid front, a line that does not give way

Not Corinth in disorder, not Galatia "so quickly deserting" (Gal 1:6)

Seen through the eyes of Epaphras

They had been taught that salvation is a gift with no works necessary — so "you need one more thing" found no foothold.

Walk the way you started

Colossians 2:6–7 · Outline IV — The measure and manner of the walk

v.6	“As you have received Christ Jesus the Lord, so walk in Him” — the full Christ, not a reduced one	**παραλαμβάνω** received, as teaching handed down
v.7a	Firmly rooted in Him — roots set in Christ when we believed, and they stay there	**ῥιζόω** Perf. Pass. — rooted, remaining so
v.7b	Now being built up in Him — story by story; the Master Builder does the work	**ἐποικοδομέω** Pres. Pass. — continuous
v.7c	Established in your faith — confirmed in the truth “just as you were instructed”	**βεβαιόω** Pres. Pass. — made firm
v.7d	Overflowing with gratitude — for everything, even the hard things	**περισσεύω** Pres. ACTIVE — our part

Three passives, one active: growth is God’s doing; thankfulness is ours.

Discuss and apply

Colossians 2:1–7 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. What was the false teachers' basic claim about Jesus, and why is it so dangerous?

2. What does it mean to walk in Christ "as you have received" Him (v.6)?

Apply

Look Deeper into Christ, Not Beyond Him
Read Colossians 1:15–2:3 slowly this week and list every treasure you find in Christ.

Walk the Way You Started
Each morning pray: "Lord, as I received You by grace, help me walk in You by grace today."

In one line: Every treasure is already in Christ — so keep walking in Him the way you began: by grace, through faith.

Beware of Philosophy

Believers must beware of any man-made philosophy that is not according to Christ, because all the fullness of Deity dwells in Him bodily, they are complete in Him, and He has forgiven them, canceled their debt and triumphed over every hostile power.

Four marks of the philosophy

Colossians 2:8 · Outline I — Beware of philosophy

A It is deceptive

κενός · ἀπάτη
“Empty deception” — it looks full, but it is hollow and meant to mislead

B It is man-made

“The tradition of men” — borrowing some biblical truth to make error palatable (cf. Mark 7)

C It is worldly

στοιχεῖα
“Elementary principles of the world” — the ABCs; rudimentary rules or elemental spirits

D It is not according to Christ

Christ was in their system — but not enough. Anything not according to Him is against Him

“Takes you captive” — συλαγωγέω, to carry off as booty. Not harmless extras, but kidnapping.

Be aware of Christ

Colossians 2:9–10 · Outline II.A–D

A His deity · v.9a

θεότης theotēs · only here
“All the fullness of Deity” — the very essence of God, nothing left out; shuts the door on kenosis

B His humanity · v.9b

σωματικῶς
“In bodily form” — a real human body: fully God and fully man, one Person

C Our sufficiency · v.10a

πληρόω periphrastic perfect
“Made complete” — same root as plērōma: made full, and remaining full

D His headship · v.10b

“Head over all rule and authority” — no chain of angelic mediators needed

He is the fullness of God, and you have been made full in Him. Live from fullness, not toward it.

Behold your share in Christ

Colossians 2:11–14 · Outline III.A–D

v.11	Circumcision without hands — spiritual, entire (“the body of the flesh”), by Christ	**ἀχειροποίητος** not made by hand
v.12	Buried and raised with Him — Spirit baptism (1 Cor 12:13), pictured by water baptism	**συνθάπτω** buried together with (Rom 6:4)
v.13a	Past condition: dead in transgressions and the uncircumcision of your flesh	**—** cf. Eph 2:1–3
v.13b	Present position: made alive together with Him, having forgiven us all our transgressions	**συζωοποιέω · χαρίζομαι** made alive · forgiven as a favor
v.14	The certificate of debt canceled, taken out of the way, nailed to the cross	**χειρόγραφον** a signed IOU

What God did with the debt

Colossians 2:14 · Outline III.D — The debt canceled

The IOU	Canceled	Taken away	Nailed to the cross
χειρόγραφον A handwritten acknowledgment of debt — “decrees against us, hostile to us”	Wiped clean, like a writing surface	Perfect tense — removed, and it stays removed	**προσηλόω** Like the charge posted over the crucified (John 19:19)
v.14a	v.14b	v.14c	v.14d

Paid in full at the cross. Nothing remains to be paid to obtain — or to keep — salvation.

The fate of the powers

Colossians 2:15 · Outline IV — Be awake to the fate of the powers

Disarmed	Displayed	Triumphed over
ἀπεκδύομαι Stripped like a defeated soldier of his armor and weapons	Paraded publicly, as captives behind a Roman general	**θριαμβεύω** Led in triumphal procession — doom sealed for all evil
v.15a	v.15b	v.15c

Believers have nothing more to fear from signs, charms or unseen powers. Christ has triumphed over them all.

Discuss and apply

Colossians 2:8–15 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. If believers are “made complete” in Christ (v.10), what does that mean for any teaching that offers something more?

2. How does the picture of the certificate of debt nailed to the cross bring assurance to a believer?

Apply

Live from Fullness, Not Toward It
Memorize Colossians 2:9–10 and recite it whenever you feel spiritually inadequate.

Remember the Nailed Debt
Write a past sin on paper, read verse 14 over it aloud, then destroy the paper — the debt is canceled.

In one line: All the fullness of God dwells in Christ — and in Him you are complete, forgiven, debt-free and on the winning side.

Study 7 of 12 · Colossians 2:16–23

Run the Race Set Before You

Because believers are complete in Christ and the Law's decrees were nailed to the cross, no one may judge them by Mosaic rules or disqualify them from their prize through false humility, mysticism or asceticism — none of which has any value against the flesh.

Five areas — no one is to judge you

Colossians 2:16 · Outline I.A — The areas of the judging

Food	Clean and unclean (Lev 11:3) — but Jesus “declared all foods clean” (Mark 7:19; cf. 1 Tim 4:3–5)	**βρῶσις** the act of eating, food
Drink	Little in the Law itself; the false teachers likely added ascetic rules (cf. Rom 14:17)	**—** vessels · Nazirite vows
Festival	Unleavened Bread, Weeks and Booths — three times a year (Deut 16:16)	**—** the annual feasts
New moon	Monthly offerings (Num 29:6); cf. Gal 4:10, “days and months and seasons”	**νεομηνία** the monthly observance
Sabbath	The only one of the Ten Commandments not repeated as a command for the Church	**σάββατον** the weekly day of rest

Believers may abstain for health or conscience (Rom 14) — but no one may make such rules a measure of spirituality.

The shadow and the substance

Colossians 2:17 · Outline I.B — The error of the judging

The shadow σκιά skia · G4639	vs	**The substance** σῶμα sōma · “body”
A mere outline — shape without substance		“The substance belongs to Christ”
The Sabbath foreshadowed rest in Christ (Heb 4:9–10)		He is the body that casts the shadow (Heb 10:1)
Passover pictured Christ, “our Passover” (1 Cor 5:7)		The realities of the New Covenant
Visible, measurable, manageable — and empty		Why grasp the shadow when you have the Person?

Strangely, people grasp what seems visible and manageable — and miss the Christ the shadows point to.

Defrauded of the prize

Colossians 2:18–19 · Outline II — Don’t let anyone disqualify you

1 False humility

ταπεινοφροσύνη
Delighting in self-abasement — the minute you know you are humble, you are not

2 Worship of angels

θρησκεία
“Humbly” approaching angels — yet every believer may come directly (Heb 4:16; Rev 19:10)

3 Visions

ἐμβατεύω
Taking a stand on visions — as an initiate enters a mystery shrine

4 Pride

φυσιόω
Puffed up like a bellows “by his fleshly mind”

5 Not holding the Head

The root problem: life, nourishment, unity and growth flow only from Christ (v.19)

★ The prize at stake

καταβραβεύω
Reward for faithful running — not eternal life, which is a free gift

Dead to the world’s religion

Colossians 2:20–22 · Outline III.A — The question

The assumption	The inquiry	The prohibitions	The explanation
“If (since) you have died with Christ to the elementary principles of the world”	**δογματίζω** “Why … do you submit yourself to decrees?” — let yourself be “dogmatized”	“Do not handle, do not taste, do not touch!” — and the list keeps growing	Perishable things, human commandments — food goes into the stomach, not the heart (Mark 7:19)
v.20a · first class condition	v.20b	v.21	v.22

Dead to sin (Rom 6:2), to self (2 Cor 5:14–15), to the Law (Rom 7:4, 6), to the world (Gal 6:14) — and here, to the world’s religion.

The appearance of wisdom — and the verdict

Colossians 2:23 · Outline III.B — The answer

They appear to be wise ἐθελοθρησκία · “self-made religion”		**They have no value** πλησμονή · “indulgence”
Self-chosen worship		Of no value against fleshly indulgence
Self-abasement		Rules may change behavior on the surface for a while
Severe treatment of the body	vs	They cannot change the heart
People like to be challenged to deny themselves		The flesh grows proud of its own rule-keeping

Four counterfeit “higher” paths: higher knowledge, higher practice, higher contemplation, higher retreat. Christ is enough.

Discuss and apply

Colossians 2:16–23 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. What is the “prize” in verse 18, and how could a believer lose it?

2. If rules cannot stop the flesh, what can?

Apply

Enjoy Your Freedom Without Judging Others
Identify one extra-biblical rule you have used to measure spirituality and lay it down this week.

Hold Fast to the Head
Set aside fifteen unhurried minutes each day for Scripture and prayer, beginning with Colossians 1:15–20.

In one line: Don’t trade the substance for the shadow: run your race holding fast to the Head, not to a list of rules.

Study 8 of 12 · Colossians 3:1–11

Looking Up, Putting Off

Because believers have been raised with Christ, their life hidden with Him in God, they are to keep seeking and setting their minds on things above — and to bring their practice up to their position by putting off the old actions, attitudes and lies. Christ is all, and in all.

The life that looks up to Christ

Colossians 3:1–4 · Outline I.A–D

Requirement	“If (since) you have been raised up with Christ” — you need the Christian life before you can live it	**συνεγείρω** first class condition (2:12)
v.1b	Keep seeking the things above, where Christ is seated at God’s right hand (Ps 110:1)	**ζητέω** Pres. Impv. — the will
v.2	Set your mind on the things above, not on the things on earth (cf. Phil 4:8)	**φρονέω** Pres. Impv. — the mind
v.3	Reason: you died, and your life is hidden with Christ in God	**κρύπτω** Perf. — concealed and safe
v.4	Reward: when Christ, our life, is revealed, you will be revealed with Him in glory	**φανερόω** made visible

The things above, already named: the canceled debt (2:14), the treasures in Christ (2:3), the Head’s supply (2:19).

Put to death the old actions

Colossians 3:5–7 · Outline II — From the specific to the comprehensive

1 Immorality

πορνεία
Every kind of sexual sin

2 Impurity

ἀκαθαρσία
Sexual uncleanness of a wider kind

3 Passion

πάθος
Uncontrolled lust that goes looking for temptation

4 Evil desire

ἐπιθυμία κακή
Craving for the forbidden (1 Pet 1:14)

5 Greed

πλεονεξία
The itch to have more — “which amounts to idolatry” (Exod 20:17)

✓ How to avoid them

Call sin by its name · send no wrong signals · think proper thoughts · stay out of compromise · flee (1 Cor 6:18)

Put aside the old attitudes

Colossians 3:8 · Outline III — “From your mouth”

Anger	A settled, abiding attitude of anger, often with a desire for revenge	**ὀργή** the settled condition
Wrath	The boiling over — an outburst of rage	**θυμός** boiling agitation
Malice	Mean-spirited ill will that wants to harm — the root beneath anger and rage	**κακία** desire to injure
Slander	Abusive speech that defames and denigrates others	**βλασφημία** defaming speech
Abusive speech	Low, obscene, foul-mouthed language	**αἰσχρολογία** only here in the NT

“Put them all aside” — like taking off old clothes. What the heart holds, the mouth eventually speaks.

Put away the old lie

Colossians 3:9–11 · Outline IV — The inconsistency and impossibility of the lie

Old self — laid aside ἀπεκδύομαι · Aor. · v.9	**New self — put on** ἀνακαινόω · Pres. Pass. · v.10	**No elite in Christ** v.11
Who we were in Adam	Being renewed continually	Racial: Greek and Jew
Put off at salvation — a past fact	“To a true knowledge” (epignōsis, 1:9)	Religious: circumcised and not
Its evil practices no longer fit	According to the image of the Creator (Gen 1:27–28; Heb 2:8–9)	Cultural: barbarian, Scythian
		Social: slave and freeman

“Christ is all, and in all.” No one has more of Christ than anyone else — the question is how much of me He has.

Discuss and apply

Colossians 3:1–11 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. Why must a person be “raised with Christ” before he can obey 3:1–2?

2. What does “Christ is all, and in all” mean for how we treat other believers?

Apply

Retrain Your Thought Life
Replace fifteen minutes of screen time each day this week with meditating on Colossians 3:1–4.

Let Christ Have All of You
Write down one area you have held back from Christ and pray daily, “Lord, have all of me here.”

In one line: Look up, then take off the old clothes: bring your practice up to your position, because Christ is all, and in all.

Study 9 of 12 · Colossians 3:12–17

Service Manual for the Lord’s Army

Because believers are chosen of God, holy and beloved, they are to put on Christlike character held together by love — and to let the peace of Christ arbitrate, the word of Christ dwell richly, and the name of Christ authorize all they do.

Why we wear the uniform

Colossians 3:12a · Outline I.A — Identity before instruction

Whose we are	What we are	Why we are
ἐκλεκτός “Chosen of God” — Scripture speaks of election to encourage believers, not to make them anxious chosen	**ἅγιοι** “Holy” — saints in position, even the troubled Corinthians (1 Cor 1:2) same word as 1:2	**ἀγαπάω** “Beloved” — loved and remaining loved; His love argues for ours Perf. Pass.

We do not dress this way to become chosen, holy and beloved. We dress this way because we already are.

What we are to wear

Colossians 3:12b · Outline I.B — “Put on” (ἐνδύω)

1 A heart of compassion

σπλάγχνα οἰκτιρμοῦ
Sensitivity to those who suffer — “your hurt in my heart”

2 Kindness

χρηστότης
A sweet disposition seen in thoughtful dealings with others

3 Humility

ταπεινοφροσύνη
A realistic view of oneself — unlike the false humility of 2:18, 23

4 Gentleness

πραΰτης
Not weakness — strength under control

5 Patience

μακροθυμία
Long-suffering that does not retaliate (1:11)

= Three groups

Treatment of others (1–2) · estimate of ourselves (3–4) · response to provocation (5)

How to wear it — and keep it on

Colossians 3:13–14 · Outline I.C–D

1	**Bearing with one another — v.13a** Putting up with others and enduring discomfort — especially when it is not comfortable	**ἀνέχω** to hold oneself up
2	**Forgiving each other — v.13b** To forgive is to give grace: no grudges, no nursing a grievance	**χαρίζομαι** built on charis
3	**“Just as the Lord forgave you” — v.13c** Freely, fully, while we were undeserving — the standard leaves no room for conditions	**Eph 4:32**
4	**Put on love — v.14** The outer garment or belt over everything else — “the perfect bond of unity”	**σύνδεσμος** a ligament, a binding

The code of conduct

Colossians 3:15–17 · Outline II.A–C

v.15	The peace of Christ is for arbitration — let it make the call, within God's revealed will; and be thankful	**βραβεύω** to act as umpire (cf. 2:18)
v.16a	The word of Christ is for application — let it dwell in you richly, at home	**ἐνοικέω** "the word of Christ" — only here
v.16b	Teaching and admonishing one another — the work of every believer, with grace	**—** cf. 1:28
v.16c	Psalms, hymns and spiritual songs, singing with thankfulness in your hearts	**ψαλμός · ὕμνος · ᾠδή** cf. Eph 5:18–21
v.17	The name of Christ is for authorization — whatever you do, in word or deed, as His representative, giving thanks	**—** principles, not rule lists

Word-filled (Col 3:16) and Spirit-filled (Eph 5:18) produce the same results: song, thanks and submission.

Discuss and apply

Colossians 3:12–17 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. Why does Paul remind believers that they are “chosen of God, holy and beloved” before giving commands?

2. How should the “peace of Christ” function in decision-making, according to the study?

Apply

Get Dressed on Purpose
Each morning this week, pray through the five virtues of verse 12 by name as you get dressed.

Forgive as You Were Forgiven
Choose to forgive that person before God in prayer, and if appropriate take one step toward reconciliation.

In one line: The Lord’s army wears Christ’s character, held together by love — ruled by His peace, filled with His Word, acting in His name.

Study 10 of 12 · Colossians 3:18–4:1

The Relationships of the New Man

In Christ every member of the household has equal worth and a God-given place: wives and husbands, children and fathers, servants and masters each serve the Lord Christ with reciprocal duties — equality of worth and order of function, both from the same Lord.

A household code like no other

Colossians 3:18–4:1 · The commentary's outline

I. Marriage · 3:18–19	II. Family · 3:20–21	III. Business · 3:22–4:1
Wives: be subject — "as is fitting in the Lord"	Children: obey — "well-pleasing to the Lord"	Servants: obey heartily — "as for the Lord"
Husbands: love — do not be embittered	Fathers: do not exasperate — lest they lose heart	Masters: justice and fairness — you too have a Master

Every member addressed directly, the one under authority first, and every person given a duty toward the other.

Submission without inferiority

Colossians 3:18 · Outline I.A — Wives

What they are to do ὑποτάσσω · a military term	**Why — creation order** ἀνήκω · “as is fitting”	**Why — the Godhead** 1 Corinthians 11:3
To rank under; arrange oneself in order	A helper suitable (Gen 2:18, 21)	“God is the head of Christ”
To “your” husband — not all men	Adam first created, then Eve (1 Tim 2:13)	The Son is fully equal with the Father, yet submits
A recognized, God-given rank in the family	Not from his head, not from his feet, but from his side (Matthew Henry)	So submission does not imply inferiority

Reciprocal duties in marriage and family

Colossians 3:19–21 · Outline I.B and II

Husbands	Love your wives — the self-giving love that seeks her good; not give-and-take affection	**ἀγαπάω** not phileō, not erōs
Husbands	Do not be embittered against them — no nagging or harshness; the same in private as in public	**πικραίνω** to make bitter
Children	Obey your parents in all things — within “in the Lord” (Acts 5:29; Eph 6:1); minor children at home	**ὑπακούω** “to hear under”
Children	“For this is well-pleasing to the Lord” — children want to please, and can learn early to please Him	**εὐάρεστος** fully agreeable
Fathers	Do not exasperate your children — praise well-doing; correct without ceaseless irritation	**ἐρεθίζω** to stir up, provoke
Fathers	“So that they will not lose heart” — discouraged, sullen, even hateful	**ἀθυμέω** disheartened

Work for an audience of One

Colossians 3:22–25 · Outline III.A — Servants

A **Obey earthly masters · v.22**

“According to the flesh” — only Christ is Master of a believer’s spirit

B **Not eye-service · v.22**

ὀφθαλμοδουλία
Not working only when the boss is watching, nor merely pleasing men

C **Heartily, as for the Lord · v.23**

ἐκ ψυχῆς
“From the soul” — wholehearted work; your real Master is in heaven

D **The reward of the inheritance · v.24**

ἀνταπόδοσις · κληρονομία
A full recompense from the Lord Christ — and no partiality (v.25)

Every believer has an inheritance by grace; there is also an inheritance-as-reward for faithful service.

Masters with a Master

Colossians 4:1 · Outline III.B and Conclusion

Treat your workers justly
ἰσότης isotēs · “equality”

Not only what the law required, but what was equitable

God hears withheld wages (Jas 5:4)

Remember your Master in heaven

Every employer is himself an employee of the Lord

He will give an account, in this life and the next

Equality of worth and order of function are not enemies. Both come from the same Lord.

Discuss and apply

Colossians 3:18–4:1 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. How does 1 Corinthians 11:3 show that submission does not mean inferiority?

2. How should “as for the Lord” (v.23) change the way an employee approaches his work?

Apply

Encourage, Don’t Exasperate
Speak at least one specific word of praise to each child or grandchild in your life every day this week.

Work for an Audience of One
Choose one routine task this week and do it with excellence, consciously offering it to the Lord.

In one line: At home and at work, every relationship is service to the Lord Christ — equal in worth, ordered in function.

Study 11 of 12 · Colossians 4:2–6

Perfecting the Prayer Life

Believers are to devote themselves to watchful, thankful prayer — including prayer for open doors and clear words for the gospel — and then to walk wisely toward outsiders, buy up every opportunity, and speak with grace seasoned with salt.

Paul’s plan for evangelism

Colossians 4:2–6 · The commentary’s outline

I. Supplication	II. Presentation	III. Implementation	IV. Conversation
προσκαρτερέω Devoted, alert, thankful prayer	**θύρα** Pray for an open door and a clear message	**ἐξαγοράζω** Walk wisely toward outsiders; buy up the opportunity	**ἅλας** Speech with grace, seasoned with salt, fitted to each person
v.2	vv.3–4	v.5	v.6

It begins on our knees, continues in our walk and is carried in our talk.

Supplication: three marks of prayer

Colossians 4:2 · Outline I.A–C

Devoted	Persist in it, be busily engaged in it — as the early church did (Acts 2:42). Not a luxury but a necessity, like breathing.	**προσκαρτερέω** to hold fast to
Alert — before	Don’t rush in unprepared; don’t let the enemy spoil your spirit first	**γρηγορέω** stay awake (Matt 26:40–41)
Alert — during	Guard against wandering thoughts — “every thought captive” (2 Cor 10:5)	**—** a meeting with the Ruler
Alert — after	Look confidently for the answer: yes, no — or wait. Keep praying.	**—** the Spirit helps (Rom 8:26)
Thankful	“With an attitude of thanksgiving” — Colossians is one of the most thankful books in the NT	**εὐχαριστία** 1:3, 12; 2:7; 3:15–17; 4:2

A believer who does not pray is demonstrating independence from God: “apart from Me you can do nothing” (John 15:5).

Presentation: pray for an open door

Colossians 4:3–4 · Outline II.A–D

A The chance · v.3a

θύρα
Not an open cell, but “a door for the word” — God is the expert in doors (Acts 16:6–7; Rev 3:7–8)

B The communication · v.3b

“The mystery of Christ” — Gentiles fellow heirs in one body (1:26–27; Eph 3:4–6)

C The complication · v.3c

δέω Perf. Pass.
Imprisoned for this very message — yet it advanced the gospel (Phil 1:12–13)

D The charge · v.4

φανερόω · δεῖ
“Make it clear in the way I ought” — clarity, not cleverness; a necessity (1 Cor 9:16)

“Push” may be a good motto for business. For gospel doors, pray — then watch and walk through them eagerly.

Our walk and our talk

Colossians 4:5–6 · Outline III–IV — Implementation and conversation

The walk — v.5
περιπατέω · ἐξαγοράζω · καιρός

Wisdom toward outsiders — what our daily walk looks like to them

Not beating people over the head with the truth

Buy up the opportunity — redeem it from the marketplace

Kairos: not clock time, but the right moment

The talk — v.6
ἅλας · ἀρτύω · ἀποκρίνομαι

Sweetness: speech always with grace

Seasoning: wholesome, attractive, not bland — occasionally a sharper word

Scripture: “how you should respond to each person”

Ready with gentleness and reverence (1 Pet 3:15)

Witness is personal: one answer does not fit everyone. Knowing how to answer requires knowing the Word (Matt 4:4, 7, 10).

Discuss and apply

Colossians 4:2–6 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. What does “keeping alert” in prayer involve, and how might it change your prayer life?

2. Paul was in chains, yet he asked for an open door rather than an open cell. What does that reveal about his priorities?

Apply

Pray for Open Doors, by Name
Write their names on a card, pray daily for an open door with each, and watch for the opportunity.

Be Ready to Answer
Write a simple gospel explanation from John 3:16, 5:24 and 6:47, and practice sharing it with a believer.

In one line: Pray on your knees, walk wisely before outsiders, and talk with grace — God opens the doors.

Study 12 of 12 · Colossians 4:7–18

Portrait of a Ministry Team

No one can do the work alone: God uses faithful helpers, a team with Jewish and Gentile members, strengths and weaknesses, and a family of believers who care for one another, fulfill their ministry and rest in His sufficient grace.

Tychicus: a certain kind of helper

Colossians 4:7–8 · Outline I.A–B

1	**A beloved brother** From Asia; with Paul on the third journey (Acts 20:4) and in Rome (Eph 6:21–22)	**ἀγαπητός** beloved
2	**A faithful servant** Trusted with the collection (Acts 20:4; 24:17) and with inspired letters — Colossians, Ephesians, likely Philemon	**διάκονος** ministering servant
3	**A fellow bond-servant in the Lord** Same level as Paul, same Master — no hint of rivalry	**σύνδουλος** co-slave
4	**His purpose** Carry the letter, report on Paul, bring news both ways, encourage their hearts (cf. 2:2)	**παρακαλέω** encourage

Onesimus: help from an unlikely source

Colossians 4:9 · Outline I.C — God supplies help for the helper

What he was	What grace made him
A runaway slave from a Colossian household — Philemon’s	Found by God and brought to Paul and the gospel (Philem 10)
He had wronged his master and fled (Philem 18)	“Our faithful and beloved brother, one of your number”
Under Roman law, facing severe punishment	A trusted messenger, carrying Philemon’s letter
Fled to Rome to get lost in the crowd	Safety in numbers on the road home with Tychicus

vs

God’s grace transforms people with a past into partners in ministry.

The team photograph

Colossians 4:10–14 · Outline II — Front row Jewish, back row Gentile

1 Aristarchus — a heart

συναιχμάλωτος
“My fellow prisoner”; seized at Ephesus (Acts 19:29), sailed with Paul to Rome

2 Mark — a future

ἀνεψιός
Turned back once (Acts 13:13), restored — later “useful to me” (2 Tim 4:11)

3 Jesus Justus — a name

“The Lord is salvation” (Matt 1:21); with these, Paul’s only Jewish fellow workers — a comfort

4 Epaphras — a passion

ἀγωνίζομαι
Always laboring in prayer that they stand mature and fully assured

5 Luke — a gift

ἰατρός
“The beloved physician” and careful historian (Luke 1:1–4)

6 Demas — a weakness

No description at all — later he deserted, “having loved this present world” (2 Tim 4:10)

Instructions to the family

Colossians 4:15–18 · Outline III

v.15	Greet the brethren — adelphoi, “from the same womb”: born of God; the same care for one another (1 Cor 12:25)	**ἀδελφοί** born of the same parent
v.15	Nympha and the church in her house — the early church met in homes (NKJV: Nymphas … his house)	**—** textual variant
v.16	Read the letters — Colossians in Laodicea; the “letter from Laodicea” here (likely Ephesians)	**—** cf. Rev 3:14–22
v.17	Archippus: “Take heed to the ministry … that you may fulfill it” — received in the Lord	**διακονία** significance · source · success
v.18	Paul’s own hand · “Remember my imprisonment” · “Grace be with you”	**μνημονεύω** authentic · real chains · abounding grace

If God calls us to a task, He equips us for it: “I will be with you” (Exod 3:12).

Colossians in review: Christ is all

Colossians 1–4 · The twelve studies

Doctrine — chapters 1–2	Practice — chapters 3–4
Christ supreme in creation, Church and cross (1:15–23)	Seek things above; put off the old, put on the new (3:1–17)
Christ in you, the hope of glory (1:27)	Serve the Lord Christ at home and at work (3:18–4:1)
All the fullness of Deity in Him — and you complete in Him (2:9–10)	Pray, walk wisely, speak with grace (4:2–6)
No shadow, rule or vision can add to Him (2:16–23)	Work as a team, fulfill your ministry, rest in grace (4:7–18)

We are not what we were. We are what we are. We shall be what we will be — all by the grace of God.

Discuss and apply

Colossians 4:7–18 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. How does Onesimus’s story display the grace of God?

2. What warning does Demas give us, and how does 1 John 2:15–16 help explain it?

Apply

Give People a Second Chance
Reach out to encourage one believer who is trying to make a fresh start.

Fulfill Your Ministry by Grace
Write your ministry in one sentence, share it with your group, and ask them to hold you accountable.

In one line: No one can do it all — God builds a team of grace and calls each member to fulfill the ministry received from Him.

Conclusion · Colossians 1–4

Christ is all, and in all

A letter written against a teaching that said Jesus was not enough — answered by Christ supreme over all, believers complete in Him, and a life that brings practice up to position, from first to last by grace.